

The Dhāraṇī Called 'Obstructing Miserliness'

Toh 648 · Derge Kangyur

འཇུ་འགགས་ནི་བ་བྱའ་གཟུགས།

Toh 648 in the Kangyur is a dhāraṇī text known in Tibetan as "Jur Geg" and in Sanskrit as the Dhāraṇī Called "Obstructing Miserliness." It belongs to the dhāraṇī section of the Kangyur and is concerned with the karmic consequences of preventing or impeding the generosity of others, a transgression said to produce results even more severe than ordinary miserliness. The text unfolds through a narrative encounter in which the noble Śāriputra and Maudgalyāyana come upon a realm of hungry ghosts and witness the horrifying physical suffering of beings reborn in that state as a direct result of having obstructed others' giving. Through this vivid framing story, the text conveys both a moral teaching on the gravity of interfering with generosity and the protective or purifying power of the dhāraṇī itself.

In the Tibetan language: The Dhāraṇī Called "Obstructing Miserliness."

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

This is the result — a fruit of wrongdoing far exceeding ordinary miserliness — arising from having obstructed another's generosity. The noble Śāriputra and the noble Maudgalyāyana, while walking together at one time, were holding in mind the analytical wisdom taught by the Blessed One, when at noon the two of them arrived at a place full of many hungry ghosts in a desolate wilderness. There was a female hungry ghost whose body was blue and withered, making hollow rattling sounds, with matted hair, red eyes rolling to the left, long lips twisted to the right, her neck and limbs extremely thin and shriveled, her nails having pierced straight through her clenched fists so that the nails showed blue. From her mouth she cried out five kinds of sounds, which were these: "I need it," "There is none," "Do not give it," "Even if you give it, it will be snatched away by a bigger one," and "That bigger one has already taken and left only a little" — these five utterances. They encountered someone who was gathering filth, and the two noble ones thought: since the village town was closer than the monastery and had plenty of food, they went to the town and gathered a great abundance of food and drink — the three white foods, the three sweet foods, rice, barley porridge, and so forth — and brought it to the female hungry ghost and offered it to her. But she would not take it; instead she cried out the five sounds as before and fled.

The two of them were deeply distressed. Entering into the mind of that female hungry ghost, forgetting everything else, they went immediately to where the Blessed One was dwelling in the Grove of Light, prostrated at his feet, then, overwhelmed and exhausted, were unable to summon the courage to ask their question.

The Blessed One declared: "Children of good family, what is the matter? If you have a question, take a breath and ask it."

"Blessed One, we are deeply distressed. We have been tormented by a great anger within ourselves."

He declared: "What brought this about?"

They said: "The two of us, at a certain time, while walking far along a path — having in mind the analytical wisdom spoken from the mouth of the Blessed One — encountered a female hungry ghost whose body was blue and withered, making hollow rattling sounds, with matted hair, red eyes rolling to the left, long lips twisted to the right, her neck and limbs extremely thin and shriveled, her nails piercing straight through her clenched fists and appearing blue. From her mouth she cried out five kinds of sounds: 'I need it,' 'There is none,' 'Do not give it,' 'Even if you give it, it will be snatched away by a bigger one,' and 'That bigger one has already taken and left only a little' — these five. We came upon someone who was gathering filth, and the two of us thought: since the village town is closer than the monastery and has food available, we went to the town and obtained a great abundance of food and drink — the three white foods, the three sweet foods, rice, barley porridge, and so forth — and brought it to that female hungry ghost and offered it to her. But she cried out those five sounds from her mouth, refused to take what was offered, and fled. We have come to ask: what has caused this, and what method of healing is there for her?"

The Blessed One declared: "Children of good family, that is most excellent. Listen well to what I shall explain and hold it in mind.

"Why her body is blue and withered: this arose because she herself could not bear to eat.

"Why her neck is thin: this arose because she was miserly toward others who were eating and enjoying food.

"Why her limbs are thin and her nails pierce straight through: this arose from her having urged others who were giving gifts to give in reduced measure —

'give with a bigger one taking the top' — and from her own inability to bring herself to make use of things.

"Why her hair is matted: this arose from having made herself disagreeable to everyone.

"Why her eyes are red: this arose from being utterly consumed by attachment and desire.

"Why her eyes roll to the left: this arose from looking upon others with an evil gaze.

"Why her lips are long and roll to the right: this arose from saying, when giving to others, 'Give such that something extra comes to me on top.'"

"Why she emits five kinds of sound from her mouth: this is a result corresponding to its cause — it arose from the accumulated habitual tendencies of what was spoken before."

"On account of karma of that kind, whatever others give her brings no benefit. She is unable to give even water by herself, since she did not obstruct others' water. Therefore, even now, if someone recites the mantra once over clean water untouched by roasted barley flour, and offers it along with a single piece of food, her stream of being will be liberated and her desires will be satisfied. The mantra is this:

Oṃ jvala midam sarvapretabhyaḥ svāhā."

Someone asked, "Please explain the meaning of its syllables."

The Blessed One declared, "Oṃ is the intrinsic nature (svabhāva) of the five wisdoms — it is the ultimate. Jvala means 'blazing like fire with desire.' Midam means 'made miserly and obstructive through the human stream of being.' Sarva means 'all those who have arisen from karma of that kind.' Preta is the very essence of the hungry ghost — it means the ripening of the stream of karma. Bhyaḥ means 'in order that karma and suffering be purified.' Svāhā means 'may karma and suffering — hunger and thirst — be purified.' Now, go quickly and give nourishment in that manner."

Thereupon the two of them went quickly and did exactly as instructed, and only then did she rejoice, enjoy her fill, and her body became moist.

Then, when the time came to teach the Dharma, the two requested it earnestly. Śāriputra offered a handful of roasted barley flour, gave one portion, and offered water as before, reciting the words again — and she fled. Again

the two were uncertain and came to report to the Blessed One. "Blessed One, we did as you instructed. It seemed she was being nourished, but fearing the Dharma teaching might fail us, we tried again, reciting as before, giving the water — and she fled again. We have come once more to report."

The Blessed One declared, "The roasted barley flour up to your wrist has been licked clean by her. Wash your hands first, and then give. You need not go to her place — this very act will suffice."

The two washed their hands, offered the water, and the hungry ghost herself came there and became slightly restored to health and color.

Then the Blessed One again declared, "This giving of water — do not limit it to this occasion alone. Make it a commitment at all times and continue it. Spread it widely to others as well. Why? Because the merit of this is immeasurable — it surpasses calculation. To state it briefly: making gifts to the wealthy of a world-realm does not come within a hundredfold of the merit of making a gift to even a single poor person. Why? Because the wealthy are consumed by pride, arrogance, and haughtiness, and take pleasure in acquiring lower rebirths. And giving to the poor of a world-realm does not come within a hundredfold of the merit of giving to even a single hungry ghost. Why? Because with the poor there is still the effort of seeking them out, still the act of calling them forth. With hungry ghosts, due to their karma, it is not so — and if what is given is not dedicated, even if it reaches their mouth it becomes a great poison. And giving to the hungry ghosts of a world-realm does not come within a hundredfold of the merit of giving water to even a single hungry ghost of the obstructed kind. Why? Because for those hungry ghosts there are those who are satisfied by being visualized, satisfied by having it arrayed before them, satisfied by having it dedicated, satisfied by having it touched, satisfied by having it directed afterward, and satisfied by having it poured — all according to the sequence of their karma.

"Now, the obstructed hungry ghost, through the karma of having blocked others, cannot be reached by mantra, by mudrā, or by any other visualization — all substances are stopped and blocked for her, so she experiences no other substance. Only others' water was not blocked by her. She is therefore without power over anything except water that is clean and untouched by roasted barley flour. The mantra that pacifies one's stream of being, and..."

a mudrā with a single crossing — nothing else is able to accomplish it. What is meant by "placed in a single crossing"? If it were divided into two, it would

become another's sound and could not be received. Therefore, it is definite as a single sound that generates one's own understanding.

This practice removes obstructions so that one cannot be impeded; it brings decrease of illness, length of life, possession of resources, and the opening of letters that are swollen shut; it makes dim complexions clear and bright. And if one spreads this to others, one's stream of being is liberated, the lineage of hungry ghosts is cut off, and ultimately one awakens to complete and perfect buddhahood.

Having declared these words, those sons of good family then...

Translator's Notes

- The title "Obstructing Miserliness" renders བཟོག་པོ་ལྷན་པོ་ — literally "obstruction/prevention of miserliness" or "blocking of stinginess." The dhāraṇī is named for its power to counteract the karmic effects of miserliness. The compound is somewhat unusual; an alternative reading would be "the dhāraṇī that blocks [the results of having blocked] generosity," but the simpler rendering is used in the translation body.

The phrase བཟོག་པོ་ལྷན་པོ་ལྷན་པོ་ལྷན་པོ་ refers specifically to obstructing another person's act of giving — a karmic misdeed described as worse than simple miserliness — and this is the cause whose fruit is depicted in the hungry ghost's condition.

The five outcries of the hungry ghost are expressions of the miser's possessive mentality surviving into her ghostly existence: craving, denial of having, refusing to give, fear of loss to a larger rival, and asserting that whatever is given will be seized. The translation renders these as direct speech to preserve their vivid quality.

The text breaks off mid-sentence in the source as provided; the passage is evidently incomplete. The Blessed One's explanation of the remaining characteristics would have continued.

- The passage breaks off mid-sentence at the end of the Tibetan excerpt, so the translation likewise ends at that point without conclusion.

The five sounds emitted from the mouth are not enumerated here; the text treats them as known from prior context.

The phrase rendered "clean water untouched by roasted barley flour" reflects a specific ritual restriction integral to this preta narrative: the obstructed hungry ghost's karma allows her access only to water that has not been contaminated by tsampa flour, a detail the text emphasizes repeatedly.

The final catalog of six modes of satisfaction for hungry ghosts — by visualization, by arranging, by dedication, by touch, by subsequent direction, and by pouring — reflects a systematic treatment of preta-feeding rites in this tradition.

- The phrase "letters that are swollen shut" renders བཟོག་པོ་ལྷན་པོ་ལྷན་པོ་ལྷན་པོ་ལྷན་པོ་, which could also refer to sealed or closed documents being opened, or perhaps blocked channels; the precise nuance is uncertain. The term ལྷན་པོ་, literally "a single crossing," refers to a specific configuration of a mudrā, the exact form of which is context-dependent and not fully determinable from text alone.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.